



ASSEMBLY POLLS 2022

GOA

MANDAL ON THE MANDOVI?

Amidst all the personal and party rivalries, a novel factor—backward caste politics—reshapes Goa's electoral map

BY KIRAN D. TARE

It's a pleasant mid-January morning in Sankhali, an old inland town in north Goa that once used to be a small but bustling entrepot connecting the coast downriver and the Ghat sections on the east. Sanquelim, they used to call it, but here, almost 25 miles from the coast, there isn't a lot of that old Lusitanian accent to things—it's more classic middle India. Pramod Sawant syncs with that modest landscape as he gets ready to leave his house for the day's campaigning—looking pretty much like the 49-year-old Ayurvedic doctor he would have been had he not joined politics.

You don't much see the Indian politician's trademark khadi uniform in these parts; India's 'common man' look defines the Goan variety of the species. Sawant is no exception—the black dial Rado watch on his wrist is the only sign of indulgence as he comes out barefoot onto the porch, outfitted in a spotted white shirt, grey trousers and a white N-95 mask. A plastic chair separates the chief minister from the queued-up crowd. After the last citizen gets his two minutes and the last written appeal is filed away, Sawant goes inside, emerges in black cut shoes and gets into his white Innova Crysta, next to the driver. The convoy is just two police vans.

At Vitthal Nagar, a nearby hamlet that had attracted eyeballs after villagers agitated against iron-ore mining for close to two months, some 60 BJP workers are gathered in a ground near a small Ganesh temple. After duly seeking the deity's blessings, the CM turns to the people, cites his "100 per cent" record in local public works and apologises for his less-than-constant presence as the local MLA. "I hope that will not deter you from blessing me in this election," he concludes. The audience cheer for their 'dotor' (doctor in Konkani).

In its first assembly election in Goa in the absence of its stalwart—Manohar Parrikar, who passed away in 2019—the BJP is banking on Sawant to pull it through to a third consecutive term. The dotor believes he has been doing more than just a holding operation. He